

made buying brand-new not just an option but a necessity for living near jobs and the city in a nicely appointed home that requires little to no maintenance.

Fingers crossed, the value of the apartment will have grown between the time you pay the deposit and stump up the full purchase price. However, there is evidence of completed apartments in capital cities taking several years to increase in value to the point where they're worth what the buyer paid, because there are so many of similar size and quality available on the market. It's a bit like buying a new car – its value drops when it leaves the showroom.

Europeans raise families in apartments, and I have firsthand experience, through my parents and my sister, who has a young daughter, that it is possible to have a happy household in an inner-city apartment. The city becomes your backyard. But it can feel like you're buying on a wing and a prayer, and you're not alone in being spooked by the unknown factor.

Display suites

These will help you get a feel for the planned apartments, but be warned – the display suite, which is made to be the best, most luxurious example of what the development offers, is not necessarily what will be delivered with your individual sale contract. I say this with the greatest respect to the many developers that meet expectations with integrity. The artist's impressions of the apartments are always stylish, but the fixtures and fittings that appear in the glossy renderings are not necessarily what will be delivered when the ribbon is cut. The finished product should not be markedly different from the advertising, but the finer details can be overlooked by inexperienced buyers seduced by the shine and heft of a marble benchtop, plush carpets and the northerly orientations of plum prototypes. Also, making changes to an apartment – shifting something as major as a wall or as seemingly small as a power point – is a lot harder than in a standalone home; in many cases, it's darn near impossible, and you're stuck living with what you have got.

That said, developers are becoming increasingly flexible; the days of every development having a hard-and-fast floorplan are over. Some – but not all, and it varies depending on the type of development – will allow you to borrow square metres from a bedroom to lend more space to the living areas. You might want to sacrifice the study nook for a larger walk-in wardrobe in the main bedroom; a second bathroom might not interest you,